SKILLNAVORA · AI TOOLS · ZAPIER TUTORIAL

Zapier: Complete Tutorial

Connect your apps without code: Zaps, triggers and actions, filters, paths, formatter, webhooks, AI steps, templates and a lead-handling project.

Edition 2026 · skillnavora.in

How to use this guide

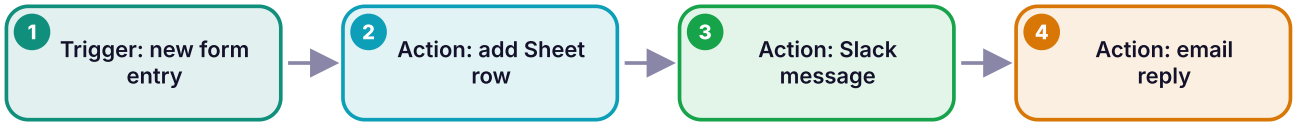
Each class has goals, concepts with Indian examples, key takeaways and a practice exercise, from basic to advanced. Finish with the final project to build something you can show in interviews.

	Class	Level
Class 1	**How Zapier works**	Basic
Class 2	**Build your first Zap: form → Sheet → Slack**	Basic
Class 3	**Logic: filters, paths, formatter, delay, lookup**	Intermediate
Class 4	**Webhooks, AI steps and Tables**	Intermediate
Class 5	**Template library: 6 Zaps to copy**	Intermediate
Class 6	**Real workflows by role: PM, sales, support, finance, HR and e-commerce**	Intermediate
Class 7	**Working with data: line items, lookups, duplicates and multi-step flows**	Intermediate
Class 8	**AI inside Zapier: classify, summarise, extract and route**	Advanced
Class 9	**Testing, monitoring, versions and team practices**	Advanced
Class 10	**Cost control and choosing between Zapier, Make, n8n and code**	Advanced
Class 11	**Three complete builds, step by step**	Advanced
Class 12	**Troubleshooting and FAQ: Zapier**	Advanced
Class 13	**Practice challenges with solutions: Zapier**	Advanced
Class 14	**Project, costs, security and limits**	Advanced
	Toolkit: templates, zapier cheat sheet, glossary, 12 interview questions, further reading	

BASIC · CLASS 1

How Zapier works

Know the building blocks and the pricing logic.



A Zap = trigger + actions

- **Zap:** one automation. **Trigger:** the event that starts it. **Action:** each step after.
- **Task:** each successful action run counts toward your plan's monthly limit; triggers and filtered-out runs don't (check the current pricing page).
- **Connections:** sign in once per app (Google, Slack, Gmail, Typeform, HubSpot, Notion...).
- **Test steps:** every step has a test that pulls real sample data to map into later steps.

Sign up at zapier.com, open **Zaps → Create**, and look at the editor: trigger on top, actions below, a **Publish** switch.

Vocabulary you will meet

Term	Meaning
Zap	One automation: a trigger and one or more actions
Trigger	The event that starts the Zap (new row, new form entry, new email)
Action	A step that does something (create row, send message)
Search action	Looks up a record (find customer by email)
Task	A successful action run counted toward your plan (check current rules)
Connection	A saved login to an app, reusable across Zaps
Zap history	Log of every run with inputs and outputs, used for debugging and replay
Folder and sharing	Organise Zaps and share with teammates
Version	Edits are saved as versions you can compare and restore

Check before you build: app names, plan limits, prices and menu labels change often. Use this lesson for the method and confirm the current screens and limits in the official docs.

Key takeaways

- Zap = trigger + actions.
- Tasks drive pricing.
- Always test each step.

Practice exercise: Sign up and list 5 things in your work that start with 'when X happens...'.

BASIC · CLASS 2

Build your first Zap: form → Sheet → Slack

Follow the steps to automate lead capture.

1. **Trigger:** choose **Google Forms** (or Typeform / Webflow) → **New Response** → connect account → pick the form → **Test trigger**.
2. **Action 1: Google Sheets → Create Spreadsheet Row**; pick the sheet; map each column (Name, Email, Phone) from the trigger data.
3. **Action 2: Slack → Send Channel Message**; text: `New lead: {Name} ({Email}, {Phone})`.
4. **Action 3 (optional): Gmail → Send Email** to the lead: "Thanks {Name}, we'll call you within 24 hours."
5. Test each step, then click **Publish**. Submit the form once to see it run in **Zap runs** (history).

Common mistakes in a first Zap

- **Testing with old data:** the sample may differ from live data; add a live test.
- **Mapping the wrong field:** check each field in the test output.
- **Duplicates:** a trigger firing on updates can create duplicates; add a search step or a unique ID check.
- **No owner:** name the Zap, add a description and choose an owner and alert email.

Key takeaways

- Map fields from earlier steps.
- Test before publishing.
- Check Zap runs history.

Practice exercise: Build this Zap and run it with 3 test form entries.

INTERMEDIATE · CLASS 3

Logic: filters, paths, formatter, delay, lookup

Make Zaps smarter without code.

Tool	Use	Example
Filter	Continue only if...	Budget ≥ ₹50,000
Paths	Branches (if/else)	Hot lead → Slack + call; Cold lead → nurture email
Formatter	Clean text, dates, numbers	Capitalise names, format phone to +91...
Delay	Wait before the next step	Send follow-up after 2 days
Lookup / Find	Search before creating	Find contact by email; update, else create (no duplicates)
Looping	Handle many items	Create a row per order item

Formatter cookbook

Task	Formatter step	Example result
Make names consistent	Text: Capitalize	ravi kumar becomes Ravi Kumar
Get the first name	Text: Split Text	Ravi Kumar becomes Ravi
Clean a phone number	Text: Replace / Extract Pattern	+91 98765-43210 becomes 9876543210
Convert date format	Date/Time: Format	2026-11-04 becomes 04 Nov 2026
Add 2 days for a follow-up	Date/Time: Add/Subtract Time	Due date
Convert currency or round	Numbers: Format	1999.5 becomes Rs 2,000
Pick one item from a list	Utilities: Line-item to Text / Pick from List	Multiple items to a single field

Key takeaways

- Filters stop, paths branch.
- Formatter cleans data.
- Look up before creating to avoid duplicates.

Practice exercise: Add a filter and a 2-path split to your lead Zap.

INTERMEDIATE · CLASS 4

Webhooks, AI steps and Tables

Connect any app and add AI.

- **Webhooks by Zapier:** *Catch Hook* gives you a URL; your website or Razorpay POSTs JSON to it; use the fields in later steps. *POST* action sends data out. Test with a webhook tester first.
- **AI steps:** add an AI/ChatGPT/Claude step ("Classify this lead as Hot/Warm/Cold and write a 2-line summary") then route on its answer.
- **Tables & Interfaces:** store records and build simple forms or approval pages (look for current names in your plan).
- **Reliability:** turn on **autoreplay**/error notifications; use Zap names and folders.

Webhook safety

- Treat the Catch Hook URL as a secret; rotate it if leaked.
- Verify a shared secret or signature header if the sender supports it.
- Return quickly; do heavy work in later steps.
- Log the payload for debugging, but mask personal data.

Key takeaways

- Catch Hook = custom trigger.
- AI step + path = smart routing.
- Turn on error alerts.

Practice exercise: Send a test webhook from webhook.site into a Zap and route on a field.

INTERMEDIATE · CLASS 5

Template library: 6 Zaps to copy

Reusable recipes for PMs and small teams.

Recipe	Trigger → Actions
Lead capture	Form → Sheet + Slack + welcome email
Meeting notes	Calendar event ends → Docs note → Slack summary
Feedback to roadmap	Typeform response → AI tag → Notion database
Payment receipt	Razorpay/Stripe payment → invoice email + Sheet row
Bug triage	Slack emoji reaction → Jira ticket
Weekly digest	Schedule (Mon 9:00) → Sheet data → AI summary → email

Key takeaways

- Start from a recipe, then adapt.
- Name steps clearly.
- Document each Zap's owner.

Practice exercise: Build two recipes and write a one-line owner note for each.

INTERMEDIATE · CLASS 6

Real workflows by role: PM, sales, support, finance, HR and e-commerce

Copy proven automations and adapt them.

Role	Workflow	Trigger → actions
Product manager	Customer feedback to backlog	New row in feedback form → AI tag and summarise → create Jira or Notion item → Slack to product channel
Product manager	Release notes to Slack and email	Jira version released → collect tickets → format text → post to Slack and email list
Sales	Lead routing	New website lead → enrich company data → score → assign owner in CRM → Slack alert for hot leads
Support	Ticket triage	New email or ticket → AI classify urgency and topic → add label → notify the right queue → send acknowledgement
Finance	Invoice capture	Invoice email arrives → extract fields (AI or parser) → add to sheet → ask approval in Slack → record in accounting tool
HR	Employee onboarding	New hire row in sheet → create accounts, calendar invites, welcome email, checklist tasks
Marketing	Webinar follow-up	Registration → add to CRM → send reminder → after event send recording and survey
E-commerce	Order notifications	New order → add to sheet → WhatsApp or SMS confirmation → alert if stock low
Fintech ops	Payment failure alerts	Webhook from gateway on failure → log → notify support channel → email the customer with retry link

For each workflow, write the trigger, the data fields you need, the exception paths (missing field, duplicate, failure) and the owner before you start building.

Key takeaways

- Start from a real repeated task.
- Plan exceptions: missing data, duplicates, failures.
- Give every Zap an owner.

Practice exercise: Pick two workflows from the table, write the field list and exception paths for each.

INTERMEDIATE · CLASS 7

Working with data: line items, lookups, duplicates and multi-step flows

Handle the tricky data problems that break automations.

- **Line items:** orders with many products arrive as lists. Use **Looping** to process each item, or convert to text for a summary message.
- **Find or create:** search for the customer by email; if found, update; otherwise create. This prevents duplicates.
- **Unique IDs:** store the source ID in the destination so reruns cannot duplicate records.
- **Missing data:** add a Filter that stops the Zap if a required field is empty, and a separate path that alerts someone.
- **Time zones and formats:** convert to Asia/Kolkata and a standard format before saving.
- **Rate limits:** add Delay steps when sending many API calls or messages.
- **Sub-Zaps / reusable parts:** where available, keep common logic (for example 'create customer') in one place.

Problem	Symptom	Fix
Duplicate rows	Same lead appears twice	Find-or-create with a unique key
Wrong value mapped	Name in phone field	Re-test, remap, add a validation filter
Zap stops on blank	Run halted	Make the field optional or add a default
Late data	Action runs before the previous record is ready	Delay or poll until ready

Key takeaways

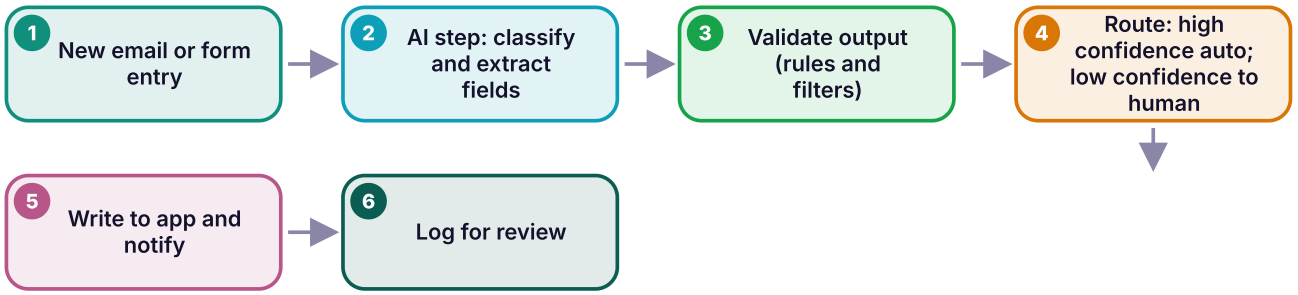
- Use find-or-create and unique IDs.
- Handle blanks and lists explicitly.
- Standardise time zones and formats.

Practice exercise: Design the duplicate-protection and missing-data logic for a lead capture Zap.

ADVANCED · CLASS 8

AI inside Zapier: classify, summarise, extract and route

Add AI steps safely.



A safe AI automation pattern

- **Good AI tasks:** classify urgency, extract fields from emails and PDFs, summarise threads, draft replies for review, translate, tag feedback.
- **Prompt format:** state the task, list allowed labels, request JSON output with fixed keys, and say what to do when unsure ('unknown').
- **Validate:** use a Filter or code step to ensure the label is in your list and required fields exist.
- **Human approval:** for emails to customers, refunds or edits to records, send a draft to Slack or email for a yes before acting.
- **Privacy:** do not send sensitive personal data to AI steps unless your policy and provider terms allow it.
- **Cost and speed:** AI steps add time and usage; test with a small batch first.
- **Agents and MCP:** Zapier offers AI agent and MCP-style features that let AI assistants use your Zaps as tools; confirm current names and limits in the docs, and restrict which actions an assistant may call.

```
Prompt example:
Classify this support email. Return JSON only:
{"topic": "refund|delivery|payment|other", "urgency": "low|medium|high", "summary": "max 20 words"}
If unsure use "other" and "low".
```

Key takeaways

- Ask for structured JSON and validate it.
- Keep a human approval step for risky actions.
- Protect personal data.

Practice exercise: Build the classification prompt and validation rules for support email triage.

ADVANCED · CLASS 9

Testing, monitoring, versions and team practices

Run automations like a product.

Practice	How
Test environment	Duplicate the Zap with test sheets or test channels; use test data
Test cases	Normal case, blank field, duplicate, long text, special characters, large list
Monitoring	Enable error alerts; weekly review of Zap history; track runs and tasks
Version history	Describe changes; restore if something breaks
Runbook	What to do if the Zap fails: who, how to replay, how to notify customers
Ownership	Name an owner and backup; review quarterly and turn off unused Zaps
Documentation	Diagram, field map, dependencies (apps, keys, sheets)

Silent failures are the real risk: an automation that stops quietly can cost leads, payments or customer trust. Always alert on errors and check volume against expectations.

Key takeaways

- Test edge cases, not only the happy path.
- Alert on errors and watch volumes.
- Document and review quarterly.

Practice exercise: Write a test plan with 6 cases and a runbook for one Zap.

ADVANCED · CLASS 10

Cost control and choosing between Zapier, Make, n8n and code

Pick the right tool for each automation.

	Zapier	Make	n8n	Custom code
Ease for beginners	Highest	High	Medium	Low
App library	Largest	Large	Large and growing; community nodes	Any API
Complex logic	Good with paths and code steps	Excellent visual routing and data handling	Excellent, with code and self-hosting	Unlimited
Pricing logic	Per task (check current)	Per operation (check current)	Per execution or self-host	Engineering time and hosting
Best for	Fast business automations	Data-heavy multi-step scenarios	Technical teams, privacy, scale	Core product logic

Reduce task usage

- Add Filters early so non-matching runs stop before using tasks.
- Combine steps (batch updates) and avoid unnecessary look-ups.
- Use schedules rather than instant triggers where real-time is not needed.
- Turn off test Zaps and delete unused ones.
- Review the top 10 Zaps by usage monthly.

Move to code or n8n when volumes are very high, logic is complex, data is sensitive or you need version control and tests in a repository.

Key takeaways

- Choose the tool for the job.
- Filter early to save tasks.
- Move heavy or sensitive flows to code or self-hosted tools.

Practice exercise: Estimate monthly tasks for your top 3 Zaps and find two ways to cut usage.

ADVANCED · CLASS 11

Three complete builds, step by step

Follow detailed blueprints you can reproduce.

Build 1: Lead desk (form to CRM to Slack)

1. Trigger: Google Forms new response.
2. Formatter: clean phone and name.
3. Search CRM contact by email; Path A (found) update; Path B (not found) create.
4. AI classify budget and urgency into hot / warm / cold.
5. Filter: hot leads post to Slack with a call-now button; others add to a nurture list.
6. Delay 2 days; if no reply status, email a follow-up.
7. Error alert and weekly summary to the owner.

Build 2: Support triage with AI and human approval

1. Trigger: new ticket or email in the support inbox.
2. AI step: topic, urgency, language, summary (JSON).
3. Validation filter: label in allowed list.
4. Route by topic to the right Slack channel or helpdesk queue.
5. AI drafts a reply; post draft to Slack with Approve / Edit buttons (interface or Slack message).
6. On approval send the reply; log in sheet with time to response.

Build 3: Order notifications and stock alerts

1. Trigger: new order from your store (webhook or app trigger).
2. Loop through line items; add to inventory sheet.
3. Send WhatsApp or SMS confirmation with order number and ETA.
4. If stock below threshold, alert the buyer team with product and quantity.
5. Daily digest of orders and issues at 6 pm.

Key takeaways

- Plan trigger, data, branches and alerts before building.
- Use find-or-create and unique IDs.
- Add summaries and error alerts.

Practice exercise: Pick one build, create it with test data, and record the test results.

ADVANCED · CLASS 12

Troubleshooting and FAQ: Zapier

Fix common problems quickly.

Problem	Likely cause	Fix
Zap did not trigger	Trigger is polling (delay), filter blocked it, or the app account is disconnected	Check Zap history, reconnect, test with a new record, confirm plan polling time
Field is empty	Sample data lacked the field	Re-test trigger with live data; map correct field; add default
Duplicate records	Trigger fires on update	Add find-or-create and a unique ID
Rate limit error	Too many calls	Add delay, batch or lower frequency
Runs but wrong result	Mapping or formatter error	Inspect inputs and outputs per step
Task usage high	No early filter; frequent triggers	Filter first; combine steps; use schedule

Debug routine: open the failing run, find the first step with a wrong output, fix that step, retest with the same input, then replay.

Key takeaways

- Debug from the first wrong output.
- Use live test data.
- Filter early to cut usage.

Practice exercise: Break a Zap on purpose in five ways and fix each.

ADVANCED · CLASS 13

Practice challenges with solutions: Zapier

Test yourself on realistic tasks.

Challenge 1

Send a Slack alert only when a new lead has budget above Rs 50,000 and is not already in the CRM.

Solution: Trigger → Search CRM by email → Filter (not found AND budget > 50000) → Create contact → Slack message.

Challenge 2

Summarise each day's support emails at 6 pm.

Solution: Schedule 6 pm → Gmail find emails of today → Digest or Looping into a list → AI summary (JSON with topics and counts) → Slack post and Sheet row.

Challenge 3

Create a task for each line item of an order.

Solution: Trigger order → Looping by Zapier on line items → Create task per item with order number and SKU → final Slack message with count.

Challenge 4

Prevent double charges when a payment webhook fires twice.

Solution: Catch Hook → Storage or Tables lookup of the payment ID → Filter (not found) → process → save the payment ID.

Key takeaways

- Practise filters, searches, loops and digests.
- Use stored IDs to prevent duplicates.
- Think through exceptions.

Practice exercise: Create your own three challenges and solutions.

ADVANCED · CLASS 14

Project, costs, security and limits

Run Zapier reliably and affordably.

Project: lead desk

Website form → AI classification → Hot leads Slack + calendar link; all leads to Sheet; Day-2 follow-up; weekly summary. Add error alerts and an owner.

- **Cost:** count tasks per run × expected volume; merge steps; use filters early.
- **Security:** least-privilege app connections; don't send personal data you don't need (DPDP); remove old connections.
- **Limits:** rate limits and polling delay on free plans; use webhooks for instant triggers.

Governance checklist

Area	Do this
Access	Use a team or company account, not a personal login; remove people when they leave
Connections	Use service accounts with least privilege
Data	Do not pass full personal data through steps unless necessary; avoid logging sensitive fields
Change control	Describe changes in the Zap description; test in a copy before editing live Zaps
Monitoring	Alert emails for errors; review failed runs weekly
Documentation	Keep an inventory: purpose, owner, systems, data, last review

Key takeaways

- Filter early to save tasks.
- Alert on errors.
- Minimise personal data.

Practice exercise: Complete the lead desk project and calculate its monthly task cost.

TOOLKIT

Templates

Zapier project brief

Field	Fill in
Trigger	
Actions (in order)	
Filters / paths	
AI step	
Error alerts + owner	
Expected tasks per month	

TOOLKIT

Zapier cheat sheet

Term / tool	Meaning / use
Zap	One automation
Trigger / Action	Start event / each next step
Task	One successful action run (billing unit)
Filter / Paths	Stop / branch
Catch Hook	Webhook trigger URL
Formatter	Built-in data cleaning
Zap runs	Run history for debugging
Find or create	Search first, create only if not found
AI step rule	JSON out, validate, human for risky
Cost rule	Filter early, batch, schedule
Debug rule	History, inputs/outputs, replay

Glossary

Search action	Step that looks up a record
Looping	Run steps for each item in a list
Line item	One row inside a multi-item field, like products in an order
Replay	Re-run a failed Zap run
Autoreplay	Automatic retry of failed runs
Service account	A non-personal account used for connections
Digest	Combining many events into one summary
Idempotent	Safe to run twice with the same result

INTERVIEW PREP

12 interview questions with answers

Q1. What is Zapier?
A no-code tool that connects apps: a trigger in one app runs actions in others.

Q2. Trigger vs action?
Trigger starts the Zap when an event happens; actions are the steps that follow.

Q3. How do you avoid duplicate records?
Use a Find/Lookup step first, then update or create.

Q4. How would you connect a custom website?
Use Webhooks by Zapier's Catch Hook URL and POST JSON from your site.

Q5. What is the difference between a Zap and a task?
A Zap is the automation workflow; a task is a counted successful action run, which is typically the billing unit (check current plan rules).

Q6. How do you avoid duplicates in Zapier?
Search before creating, store a unique ID, use filters to ignore updates you do not need, and test reruns.

Q7. When should you use Paths versus Filters?
Use a Filter to stop a Zap when a condition is not met; use Paths to run different branches for different conditions.

Q8. How would you add AI safely in an automation?
Ask for structured output, validate it, send low-confidence or risky cases to a human, protect personal data and monitor results.

Q9. How do you debug a failing Zap?
Open the Zap history, inspect the failing step's inputs and outputs, fix the mapping or data, replay, and add tests for that case.

Q10. When would you not use Zapier?
For very high volumes, complex logic needing tests and version control, sensitive data that must stay in your systems, or core product features.

Q11. How do you control Zapier costs?
Filter early, batch, use schedules when real-time is not needed, remove unused Zaps and monitor top consumers.

Q12. How do you secure webhook-triggered Zaps?
Keep the URL secret, validate a shared secret or signature, avoid logging sensitive data and rotate the hook if leaked.

LEARN MORE

Further reading and tools

- Zapier Learn ↗
- Zapier Help Center ↗
- Zapier templates ↗
- Webhooks by Zapier ↗
- Zapier AI and agents (docs) ↗
- Zapier community ↗

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